

Hindutva laboratory, pursuing policies centred around identity and homogeneity. The abolition of madrasas marks another milestone, keeping the saffron visage intact as the state nears its next assembly poll in February 2027.

The new framework dismantles the Uttarakhand Madrasa Education Board, which functioned under an eponymous 2016 Act, besides the Uttarakhand Non-Government Arabic and Persian Madrasa Recognition Rules, 2019. Both stand repealed—replaced by last year's Uttarakhand Minority Education Act (UMEA 2025) and the Uttarakhand Minority Educational Institutions Recognition Rules, 2026. The first was drafted by a special committee chaired by the CM; many of its members had also played a key role in framing the UCC.

Takeaways

- **Uttarakhand scraps madrasa board, brings all minority schools under new body**
- **Schools run by all six notified minorities will need to apply anew under it**
- **After UCC, CM Dhami is refurbishing Hindutva cred before '27 poll**

The change affects all 452 recognised madrasas in the state. They will now come under the new Uttarakhand State Authority for Minority Education (USAME). Though the Islamic schools are popularly seen as the ones least conforming to the mainstream, USAME's word will be law for Christian, Sikh, Jain, Buddhist and Parsi institutions as well.

All of them will be required to seek recognition all over again from USAME after affiliating themselves with the Uttarakhand Board of School Education. Applications will be scrutinised by the 12-member authority, which may also conduct physical inspections before granting approval. They will then be yoked to the National Education Policy (NEP) and its National Curriculum Framework. Along with religious instruction, students will study NCERT-based subjects like Mathematics, Science, Computer Science, Social Science. Dhami calls it a landmark reform that's "not intended to affect the identity or traditions of any community" but to make modern education uniform.

In 2025, a crackdown had sealed over 200 "unrecognised madrasas". Recent months have also seen a demographic survey, and strong-handed moves against alleged land encroachment and food safety violations. The CM frequently laced these drives with terms such as "land jihad", "love jihad" and "thook jihad". Critics call these identity-based drives targeting Muslims—citing erasure via renaming, and now the madrasa abolition.

LEGAL OVERHAUL

It's not a state short of woes. The 'Second Chipko Movement', partly urban now, is peaking over 4,000 Shivalik trees being felled around Rishikesh airport. Denizens of Devprayag—the Ganga attains its fullest mountain form here—were recently protesting lack of drinking water. Paper leaks saw angry student protests last fall, and Ankita Bhandari is only one of a string of cases that triggered Nirbhaya-like mass outrage—the latest signs of street anger came in May after a politically motivated acquittal in a Champawat case.

It's never a bad time, in short, to bring a flagship policy. ■

RAJASTHAN

Flight Time for Pilot?

The state unit chief's post is up for grabs—but the inheritor-in-waiting is not the only contender now

By **Rohit Parihar**

IF THE LEADERSHIP QUESTION IN RAJASTHAN has been a cipher wrapped in a dilemma for the BJP, it presents a tense mystery novel for the Congress as well—and it's time to turn the page. As Govind Singh Dotasra completed six years as state unit chief on July 14, the high command is back to the first eight squares of the chess board. It could move many pieces—and they can all move in unpredictable ways.

Status quo is an option, so is status quo ante. Neither is without risk. The questions to consider include equations among leaders, their competing ambitions, as well as caste. Dotasra, 61, has hit what's regarded as the upper limit for a state chief's tenure. But it's not a

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